

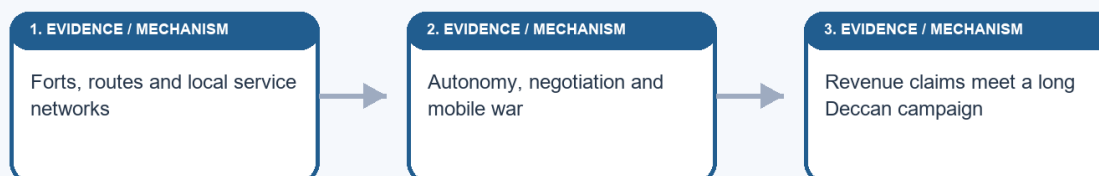
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Marathas, Shivaji & Aurangzeb's Deccan; Jagirdari Crisis - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Maratha state-building and Mughal Deccan strain

ORIGINAL TOPIC STUDY VISUAL



Read the arrows as an analytical relation, not as an automatic or single-cause explanation.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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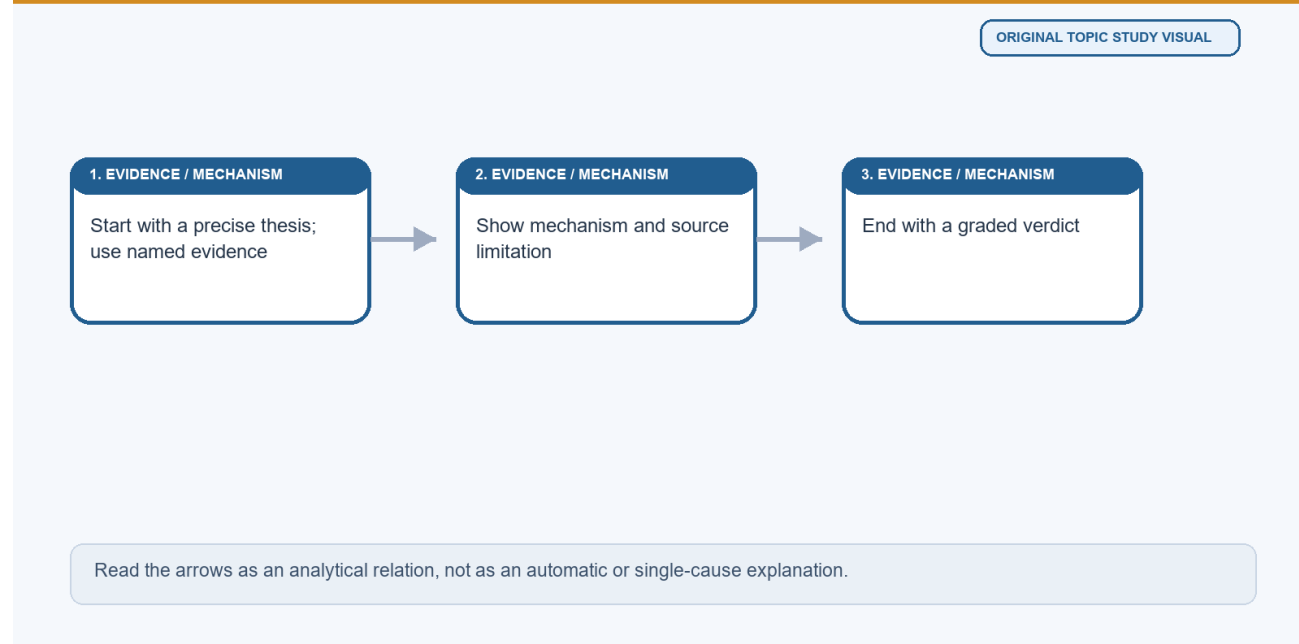
The Marathas, Shivaji & Aurangzeb's Deccan; Jagirdari Crisis - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Learning MCQs (20; key rotation A -> B -> C -> D repeated five times)

Correct options are deliberately rotated by actual option placement, not by relabeling: A -> B -> C -> D through the full set. Read the explanation after attempting each item.

Mains answer spine: claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification



Visual 78: answer evidence spine

Visual 78: answer evidence spine. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Q1. Why is western Deccan geography relevant to Shivaji's rise?

- A. It offered routes, nodes and constraints that political organisation could exploit.
- B. It prevented all Mughal movement.
- C. It made diplomacy unnecessary.
- D. It mechanically created a unified Maratha nation.

Answer: A. Explanation: Terrain shaped choices, especially passes, forts and logistics. The closest distractor is the national-destiny claim, which confuses enabling conditions with automatic political unity.

Q2. Which formulation best describes the early Murumbdev-Rajgad episode?

- A. It was a Portuguese coastal fort.
- B. It should distinguish development/refortification and renaming from a simple capture label.
- C. It had no role in the Poona-Maval base.
- D. It was obtained only after the 1665 treaty.

Answer: B. Explanation: The discriminator is the action verb: Murumbdev's development as Rajgad is not the same claim as a clean capture. The 1665 option confuses the early fort phase with Purandar.

Q3. What did the conquest of Javli in 1656 most directly change?

- A. It transferred Surat customs to Shivaji.

- B. It completed Mughal annexation of Bijapur.
- C. It strengthened access from Maval toward Satara and the Konkan while eliminating a rival political position.
- D. It created the Ashtapradhan as a cabinet.

Answer: C. Explanation: Javli's importance is territorial and political: routes, manpower and the More challenge. The Surat option imports a separate commercial episode.

Q4. Which statement is most defensible about Afzal Khan at Pratapgad?

- A. Only supernatural explanation can explain the result.
- B. Every contemporaneous source gives an identical sequence.
- C. The episode ended all Bijapur-Maratha conflict.
- D. The meeting involved mutual suspicion and armed precautions, while the exact first blow varies by source.

Answer: D. Explanation: The correct approach separates a secure core from disputed sequencing. The 'identical source' distractor ignores courtly and later narrative variation.

Q5. The 1663 Poona raid is best used as evidence that:

- A. Mughal occupation could be vulnerable to local intelligence and surprise.
- B. Shivaji had already conquered all Mughal India.
- C. Artillery was irrelevant to early modern war.
- D. No Mughal force remained in the Deccan.

Answer: A. Explanation: It challenged the image of secure occupation, not the existence of Mughal power. The all-India option converts a raid into implausible territorial conquest.

Q6. What is the safest reading of Surat's sack in 1664?

- A. It was only a religious attack.
- B. It affected a major commercial- imperial port and must be studied through source-specific claims.
- C. It was a modern national tax collection.
- D. European factory records are neutral totals of loot.

Answer: B. Explanation: Surat linked commerce and imperial prestige. Factory records help but remain merchant sources, so the 'neutral totals' claim is the closest but wrong shortcut.

Q7. Which Purandar term is securely retained in the topic evidence?

- A. All 35 forts were permanently surrendered.
- B. The treaty created an independent modern republic.
- C. Shivaji ceded 23 forts, retained 12, and Sambhaji received mansab 5000.
- D. No service obligation was involved.

Answer: C. Explanation: The 23/12 division and Sambhaji's 5000 mansab anchor the treaty. 'All 35' confuses surrender language with the retained territorial base.

Q8. Why is Purandar better described as an incorporation attempt than a final surrender?

- A. It abolished Bijapur immediately.
- B. It required Aurangzeb to abdicate.
- C. It ended all later Mughal-Maratha contact.
- D. It combined territorial concessions with service, mansab and continuing strategic bargaining.

Answer: D. Explanation: The agreement tried to fit Shivaji into a Mughal-led forward policy. The 'ended contact' option misses Agra and renewed conflict.

Q9. Which claim about Agra in 1666 is source-critical?

- A. Escape after confinement is secure; basket or sweetmeat staging should be labelled a version.
- B. No confinement occurred.
- C. It was a coronation ceremony.

- D. The event proves every later legend literally.

Answer: A. Explanation: The distinction is event versus narrative detail. The literal-legend option treats later retelling as a court transcript.

Q10. The 1674 coronation most directly expressed:

- A. A twentieth-century nation-state constitution.
- B. Sovereignty and status in contemporary political and ritual idiom.
- C. The abolition of all Deccani borrowing.
- D. A guarantee of universal acceptance of genealogy.

Answer: B. Explanation: Coronation raised royal status and legitimacy; it was not modern independence. The genealogy option ignores visible status debate.

Q11. Why is the Ashtapradhan not a modern cabinet?

- A. It replaced fort administration entirely.
- B. It had no named offices.
- C. Its officers were individually responsible to the ruler and could hold non-modern combinations of duties.
- D. It was elected by universal franchise.

Answer: C. Explanation: The eight offices existed, but collective cabinet responsibility did not. The 'no named offices' distractor contradicts the office list.

Q12. What is the best use of Annaji Datto's assessment?

- A. As proof that every cultivator everywhere paid exactly two-fifths.
- B. As proof that intermediaries disappeared.
- C. As a navy-building programme.
- D. As evidence of measurement-based state capacity with variable local incidence.

Answer: D. Explanation: Assessment improves estimation, not uniform outcome. The exact universal rate option confuses a debated source claim with actual collection.

Q13. How do chauth and sardeshmukhi differ?

- A. Chauth is a one-quarter contribution claim; sardeshmukhi is an additional ten-percent superior-deshmukh claim.
- B. Both are names for mansab rank.
- C. Sardeshmukhi is a sea-fort tax only.
- D. Both are exactly the same one-quarter levy.

Answer: A. Explanation: The percentage and asserted rationale distinguish the two. The same-levy option is the standard Prelims trap.

Q14. Which description fits ganimi kava best?

- A. A modern ideology of mass revolution.
- B. A repertoire of mobility, intelligence, surprise and supply disruption.
- C. A permanent refusal to use forts.
- D. A doctrine that cavalry never mattered.

Answer: B. Explanation: The term should not be modernised into ideology. Fort support and cavalry both remain within the operational repertoire.

Q15. Why should Shivaji's navy not be called a blue-water empire navy?

- A. It had no relationship to forts.
- B. It used no local sailors.
- C. Its evidence supports regional coastal and creek defence, trade and pressure rather than oceanic supremacy.
- D. It existed only after 1707.

Answer: C. Explanation: Regional maritime capacity is significant without imagined oceanic scale. The 'only after 1707' option breaks chronology.

Q16. Which formulation best captures religious legitimacy under Shivaji?

- A. Royal ritual made diplomatic pragmatism impossible.
- B. Administration was exclusively Hindu and created from nothing.
- C. All sources prove uniform tolerance.
- D. Hindu royal idiom coexisted with Deccani-Persianate borrowing and differentiated personnel.

Answer: D. Explanation: The answer holds idiom and institutional plurality together. Exclusivity is the closest ideological oversimplification.

Q17. What was the consequence of annexing Bijapur and Golconda?

- A. The empire gained territory and claimants while losing buffers and adding administrative burdens.
- B. It converted jama into hasil without collection.
- C. It automatically ended Maratha resistance.
- D. It removed all need for garrisons.

Answer: A. Explanation: Annexation widened sovereign claim but deepened the governing problem. The jama-hasil option mistakes paper assessment for realised resources.

Q18. Why did Sambhaji's execution not end resistance?

- A. No fiscal collection continued.
- B. It removed a recognised head and helped shift war toward dispersed commanders and networks.
- C. All forts surrendered immediately.
- D. Aurangzeb withdrew from the Deccan.

Answer: B. Explanation: Decentralisation made resistance harder to negotiate, not impossible. The immediate-fort-surrender claim invents a total collapse.

Q19. What is the analytical value of Tarabai's role after 1700?

- A. She had no connection with administration.
- B. She ended all Mughal military capacity in one battle.
- C. It shows political leadership in regency, legitimacy and resistance rather than symbolic widowhood.
- D. She belongs only to a nineteenth-century reform story.

Answer: C. Explanation: Tarabai organised a continuing political-military field. The one-battle option reproduces a hero-story rather than a mechanism.

Q20. What does jama-hasil mismatch mean?

- A. It proves immediate state bankruptcy.
- B. Hasil is another word for coronation.
- C. Every jagir had no assessed revenue.
- D. Assessed revenue can exceed what is actually collected, weakening service and troop maintenance.

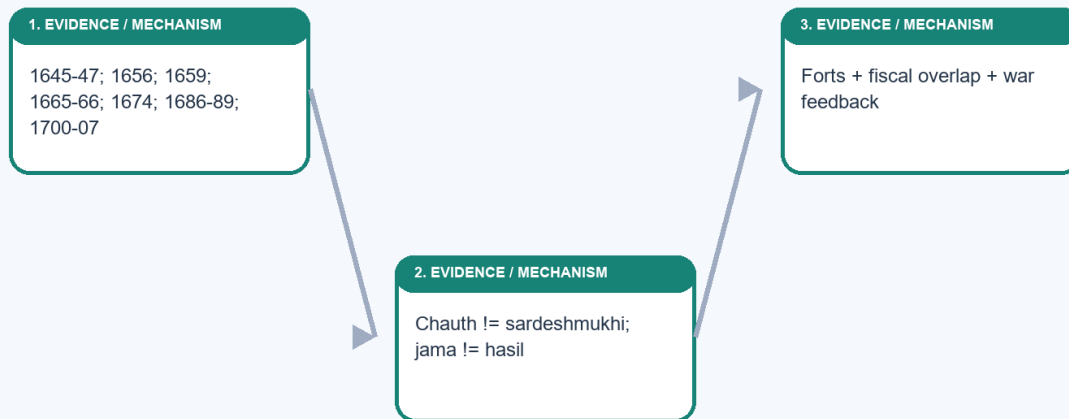
Answer: D. Explanation: The gap explains fiscal strain; it does not prove total collapse. The bankruptcy claim ignores continued imperial capacity.

Broad MCQs (44; key rotation A -> B -> A -> D repeated eleven times)

Correct options are deliberately rotated by actual option placement, not by relabeling: A -> B -> A -> D through the full set. Read the explanation after attempting each item.

Rapid recall: dates, distinctions and causal chains

ORIGINAL TOPIC STUDY VISUAL



Read the arrows as an analytical relation, not as an automatic or single-cause explanation.

Visual 79: rapid recall before practice

Visual 79: rapid recall before practice. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Q21. Which feature best explains why forts mattered in state-building?

- A. They linked garrison, store, communication, refuge and local command.
- B. They eliminated need for revenue.
- C. They were permanent symbols that never changed hands.
- D. They were decorative residences only.

Answer: A. Explanation: A fort was a multi-function node. The 'never changed hands' distractor ignores siege and recapture cycles.

Q22. Which actor should not be erased from Maratha mobilisation?

- A. No local intermediary existed.
- B. Deshmukhs and village elites with their own hereditary and local interests.
- C. Only Mughal officials mattered.
- D. Only a homogeneous warrior caste mattered.

Answer: B. Explanation: Mobilisation used differentiated social actors. Homogeneity is the tempting but false shortcut.

Q23. Why is Shahji's career relevant?

- A. It began after Shivaji's coronation.
- B. It makes Jija Bai historically irrelevant.
- C. It reveals shifting service across Deccan courts and a Poona/Karnataka political setting.
- D. It proves a fixed anti-Mughal identity from birth.

Answer: C. Explanation: Shahji's mobility is evidence of a service world, not a prewritten nationalism. The fixed identity option overreads later outcome.

Q24. What is the best source-critical use of Bhakti context?

- A. Every saint commanded the army.
- B. It replaces administrative records.
- C. It proves all groups had identical interests.
- D. It can illuminate a cultural setting but not automatically prove a direct state programme.

Answer: D. Explanation: Devotional literature does not transparently dictate policy. The administrative-record option confuses genres.

Q25. Why does the More-family episode at Javli matter?

- A. It shows territorial consolidation through elimination of a rival, route control and manpower access.
- B. It was only a coastal naval battle.
- C. It created the 1689 execution.
- D. It was a Mughal court ritual.

Answer: A. Explanation: Javli joined political coercion to strategic geography. The naval distractor mislocates its Maval-Satara-Konkkan logic.

Q26. What is a sound inference from Pratapgad?

- A. Terrain alone guarantees victory.
- B. A prepared local force could convert terrain and intelligence into political advantage.
- C. All later sources are equally reliable.
- D. Bijapur ceased to exist in 1659.

Answer: B. Explanation: The mechanism combines preparation, place and organisation. Terrain determinism is the closest but inadequate explanation.

Q27. Which statement about Pavan Khind is appropriate?

- A. Date it after 1707.
- B. Treat every devotional retelling as court record.
- C. Separate the historical withdrawal context from later tradition's detailed narrative.
- D. Reject all memory as worthless.

Answer: C. Explanation: Source qualification preserves both event and memory without flattening them. 'All memory worthless' is the opposite error.

Q28. Why did Shaista Khan's large force face a strategic problem?

- A. It had no cavalry.
- B. It was stationed in Bengal.
- C. It could not use any forts.
- D. Occupation required information and control across terrain while other fronts competed for attention.

Answer: D. Explanation: Scale does not equal local control. The Bengal option simply removes the campaign from its setting.

Q29. What can European factory records contribute for Surat?

- A. Merchant-facing evidence of commercial shock and rumour, checked against their interests.
- B. A proof that no Indian actors traded.
- C. An automatically complete military archive.
- D. A replacement for all Persian sources.

Answer: A. Explanation: Factory records provide a commercial lens, not neutral total knowledge. The 'complete archive' option overstates genre reach.

Q30. What did Jai Singh's policy toward Shivaji seek?

- A. To avoid any Bijapur policy.

- B. To combine pressure and accommodation within a forward Deccan strategy.
- C. To abolish Mughal hierarchy immediately.
- D. To make all forts independent.

Answer: B. Explanation: Jai Singh saw use in incorporation and a Bijapur-oriented strategy. 'Avoid Bijapur' reverses the policy context.

Q31. Which Purandar reading is erroneous?

- A. It included Sambhaji's mansab.
- B. It involved a territorial concession.
- C. It was a permanent end to Mughal-Maratha conflict.
- D. It retained a Shivaji base.

Answer: C. Explanation: The permanent-end statement is wrong because Agra and later conflict followed. The other options identify why it was an incorporation attempt.

Q32. What made rank at Agra politically important?

- A. It settled jagir realisation.
- B. Rank was a private matter with no political meaning.
- C. It concerned only naval vessel size.
- D. Court placement expressed the status relationship that Shivaji was contesting.

Answer: D. Explanation: Court hierarchy was political grammar. The jagir option belongs to a different analytical arena.

Q33. Which caution applies to the second coronation claim?

- A. Mention it only with a verified source and stated ritual rationale.
- B. Invent expenditure to show royal power.
- C. Treat it as a modern election.
- D. Assume it proves universal consent.

Answer: A. Explanation: Ritual repetition needs source-specific explanation. Universal consent cannot be inferred from an elite ceremony.

Q34. The southern expedition is best analysed as:

- A. A proof the Deccan had no local rulers.
- B. A move for strategic depth, resources and dynastic-political leverage.
- C. A replacement for fort policy.
- D. A full eighteenth-century confederacy history.

Answer: B. Explanation: The episode expands southern reach but should remain bounded. Importing later confederacy history is an ownership error.

Q35. Which office pair is correctly associated with justice and religious grants?

- A. Peshwa and Senapati only.
- B. Bargir and silhedar.
- C. Nyayadhish and Panditrao.
- D. Havaladar and Koli.

Answer: C. Explanation: Nyayadhish and Panditrao are differentiated offices. Bargir/silhedar are cavalry categories, a plausible but wrong pairing.

Q36. Why is later Peshwa power a poor guide to seventeenth-century Ashtapradhan functioning?

- A. It denies coronation happened.
- B. It makes jama equal hasil.
- C. It adds too many forts to a map.

- D. It projects a later political balance backward onto ruler-centred offices.

Answer: D. Explanation: Chronological projection is the error. The fiscal equation is unrelated to the office-function question.

Q37. What is the function of divided fort offices?

- A. They can create checks across command, records and stores.
- B. They eliminate military command.
- C. They make villages irrelevant.
- D. They prove every fort used an identical constitution.

Answer: A. Explanation: Checks are a useful model, but variation remains. Universal identical-chart claims exceed the evidence.

Q38. Which statement fits local administration?

- A. Forts alone collected all revenue.
- B. Central orders moved through inherited local authority and negotiation.
- C. Every deshmuks became a Mughal emperor.
- D. All patils and kulkarnis disappeared.

Answer: B. Explanation: The state used intermediaries rather than abolishing them. 'Forts alone' turns a node into an entire revenue system.

Q39. What is the key caution about cash salary claims?

- A. They mean no fort required stores.
- B. They abolished agriculture.
- C. They indicate a regular-troop preference in some contexts, not the disappearance of all local/service ties.
- D. They prove all soldiers were cavalry.

Answer: C. Explanation: Cash payment can enhance control without remaking all social relations. The agriculture distractor is a deliberately exaggerated inference.

Q40. Why distinguish assessment from collection?

- A. A rate is always uniform.
- B. Collection occurs only at coronation.
- C. Assessment has no relation to revenue.
- D. A measured demand can remain unrealised because of locality, resistance and enforcement.

Answer: D. Explanation: The chain from jama to hasil is the point. Uniform-rate reasoning mistakes administrative intention for actual incidence.

Q41. What is a correct statement about deshmuks?

- A. Their power could be curbed and negotiated without being wholly abolished.
- B. They were invented after 1707.
- C. They were identical to all cultivators.
- D. They had no local role.

Answer: A. Explanation: Continuity plus constraint is more accurate than abolition. The 'identical cultivators' option removes a key intermediary distinction.

Q42. Why is chauth not automatically sovereignty?

- A. It was exactly sardeshmukhi.
- B. A payment claim can operate amid overlapping authority and coercive bargaining.
- C. It always ended Mughal officials' presence.
- D. It was a Buddhist monastic levy.

Answer: B. Explanation: Collection practice can erode authority without formal territorial transfer. The exactly-same option confuses chauth with sardeshmukhi.

Q43. Which statement identifies sardeshmukhi?

- A. A Mughal mansab of 5000.
- B. A one-quarter naval customs duty.
- C. An additional ten-percent claim justified by superior deshmukh right.
- D. A fort commander title.

Answer: C. Explanation: The ten-percent superior-right claim is the defining distinction. The 5000 distractor imports Sambhaji's mansab.

Q44. What should a comparison of bargir and silhedar foreground?

- A. A ban on cavalry movement.
- B. A religious divide in all units.
- C. An identical state-provided horse for both.
- D. The relation of horse/equipment maintenance to military organisation.

Answer: D. Explanation: Ownership/maintenance is the discriminator. Religious essentialism adds a division not supplied by the categories.

Q45. Which statement best qualifies 'guerrilla warfare' here?

- A. Use a period-sensitive repertoire of mobility rather than a modern ideological label.
- B. It means never negotiating.
- C. It means no intelligence was needed.
- D. It makes naval strategy impossible.

Answer: A. Explanation: Ganimi kava concerns tactical practice, not a full modern revolutionary ideology. 'Never negotiating' ignores Shivaji's diplomacy.

Q46. What is the relationship between forts and mobility?

- A. Forts prevent all intelligence gathering.
- B. Fort stores and nodes can make rapid movement sustainable.
- C. Mobility means forts were unnecessary.
- D. Only coastal forts mattered.

Answer: B. Explanation: Mobility needs logistical support. The unnecessary-fort claim misses the system relationship.

Q47. What makes the Mughal-Maratha military comparison analytical?

- A. It assumes all Mughals fought only on foot.
- B. It ignores terrain and logistics.
- C. It compares campaign logics and constraints rather than stereotypes of strong versus weak.
- D. It declares artillery permanently useless.

Answer: C. Explanation: A comparison asks where each system faced costs. The terrain-ignoring option destroys the very explanatory frame.

Q48. Which coastal proposition is sound?

- A. The coast had no relation to trade.
- B. Only Europeans could navigate it.
- C. All vessels had the same role.
- D. Sea forts, creeks, customs and local sailors made the coast a political arena.

Answer: D. Explanation: Coastal strategy joined commerce and defence. 'Only Europeans' erases Koli, Bhandari, Muslim and other local expertise.

Q49. Why are vessel counts risky?

- A. Fleet scale and terminology need documentary support and should not be inflated.
- B. Counts prove every battle legend.
- C. A coastal force equals a global empire.
- D. No vessels existed.

Answer: A. Explanation: Caution prevents blue-water mythmaking. The global-empire option turns regional capacity into an unsupported claim.

Q50. What does Persianate borrowing demonstrate?

- A. All personnel were religiously identical.
- B. Shivaji's state adapted Deccani institutional resources alongside Hindu royal idiom.
- C. No administration existed before 1674.
- D. Royal idiom was absent.

Answer: B. Explanation: Adaptation is compatible with indigenous sovereignty claims. The absent-royal-idiom choice is the opposite simplification.

Q51. How should claims about protected religious sites be handled?

- A. By treating every anecdote as uniform policy.
- B. By refusing all source criticism.
- C. By naming site, act, date, source genre and corroboration before generalising.
- D. By using modern litigation as medieval proof.

Answer: C. Explanation: Precise verbs and provenance matter. The uniform-policy option turns a local claim into an empire-wide conclusion.

Q52. Why is a direct Bhakti-to-state claim risky?

- A. It proves no Marathi world existed.
- B. Bhakti had no cultural significance.
- C. All literature is false.
- D. Devotional context does not itself demonstrate a political command or programme.

Answer: D. Explanation: The caution concerns inferential reach, not cultural irrelevance. 'No significance' is the straw-man alternative.

Q53. What changed after Sambhaji's death?

- A. Resistance could use decentralised command, fort and fiscal networks more diffusely.
- B. Jinji vanished from strategy.
- C. The Marathas ceased to collect revenue.
- D. The Deccan became administratively simple.

Answer: A. Explanation: Loss of a head did not erase infrastructure. The simplicity option reverses the decentralisation mechanism.

Q54. Why did Jinji matter to Rajaram?

- A. It was inside Surat port.
- B. It offered distance and fortification as strategic depth against imperial concentration.
- C. It ended need for all supplies.
- D. It was a post-1707 British capital.

Answer: B. Explanation: Strategic depth changes campaign geometry, not logistical needs. The no-supplies claim is an obvious but instructive false inference.

Q55. What is historically important about Santaji and Dhanaji?

- A. They fought only naval battles.

- B. They made all local mediation vanish.
- C. They illustrate pressure on communications and dispersed deployments within a networked war.
- D. They were the two Ashtapradhan religious officers.

Answer: C. Explanation: Their importance is operational, not office-list or exclusive naval role. The office distractor confuses military leaders with the council.

Q56. What does Tarabai's regency demonstrate?

- A. That no commanders mattered.
- B. That succession ended in 1680.
- C. That Mughal campaigning ceased in 1700.
- D. Political agency in organising legitimacy, patronage and resistance after Rajaram's death.

Answer: D. Explanation: Tarabai's leadership needs to be treated as action, not symbolism. The final distractor contradicts the fort-campaign phase.

Q57. What is the analytical meaning of a siege-recapture cycle?

- A. Tactical capture may yield weak strategic return when the adversary can recover nodes.
- B. Every capture proves permanent sovereignty.
- C. Only one side ever used forts.
- D. Sieges require no logistics.

Answer: A. Explanation: Cycles explain attrition and weak returns. Permanent-sovereignty is the map-colouring fallacy.

Q58. Which is a defensible description of Aurangzeb's motivations?

- A. No imperial aim existed.
- B. Several aims - sovereignty, security, sultanate politics and Maratha subjugation - interacted.
- C. Only one religious motive explains every decision.
- D. The Deccan was outside Mughal concern.

Answer: B. Explanation: Multi-causality is not evasion; it matches different policy arenas. The single-motive option is reductive.

Q59. Why did annexation worsen administration?

- A. Annexation removed local bargaining.
- B. It shortened all communications.
- C. New land and nobles added claims while distance, garrisons and low realisation added costs.
- D. More territory always means more cash in hand.

Answer: C. Explanation: Nominal expansion is not realised resource. The cash-in-hand claim mistakes jama for hasil.

Q60. What makes a missed-settlement argument cautious?

- A. It supplies exact unrecorded promises.
- B. It claims history had only one inevitable path.
- C. It removes all agency from Shivaji.
- D. It identifies plausible alternatives while recognising autonomy, mistrust and uncertainty.

Answer: D. Explanation: Counterfactuals must be bounded. Inevitable-path reasoning is the opposite of historical contingency.

Q61. What does mansab describe in this context?

- A. Rank and service obligation within Mughal administrative-military organisation.
- B. A Maratha coastal fort.
- C. A synonym for chauth.

- D. The realised collection of a jagir.

Answer: A. Explanation: Mansab is not jagir or hasil. The realised-collection option deliberately confuses rank with fiscal outcome.

Q62. What does be-jagiri add beyond a count of nobles?

- A. It means every noble was a cultivator.
- B. It highlights shortage of assignable productive or usable revenue assignments.
- C. It is the same as a navy shortage.
- D. It proves no jagir had a jama.

Answer: B. Explanation: Productivity and usability are central. The navy option makes a fiscal term absurdly literal.

Q63. Why do inflated Deccan assessments matter?

- A. They end transfer corruption.
- B. They abolish garrison costs.
- C. They can create nominal revenue claims that war-disturbed districts cannot realise.
- D. They guarantee high hasil.

Answer: C. Explanation: An inflated jama worsens the paper-realisation gap. Guaranteed-hasil is the exact misconception to avoid.

Q64. How do private pacts affect sovereignty?

- A. They prove local actors were passive.
- B. They eliminate all coercion.
- C. They automatically create legal independence.
- D. They can secure local relief while normalising parallel fiscal authority.

Answer: D. Explanation: Pacts are negotiated practical arrangements, not automatic formal cession. Passive-local-actor reasoning misses mediation.

Remedial MCQs (16; key rotation A -> B -> A -> D repeated four times)

Correct options are deliberately rotated by actual option placement, not by relabeling: A -> B -> A -> D through the full set. Read the explanation after attempting each item.

Fact-risk ledger: high-risk claims

ORIGINAL TOPIC STUDY VISUAL

1. EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

Early forts; Afzal; Agra;
revenue; Hindavi Swarajya

2. EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

Navy size; Sambhaji details;
jagirdari terminology

3. EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

Mark certainty, provenance
and limit

Read the arrows as an analytical relation, not as an automatic or single-cause explanation.

Visual 75 repeat: fact-risk checks for distractors. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Q65. Which answer rejects geography determinism?

- A. Terrain enabled specific choices; organisation and local politics made them effective.
- B. No actor made strategic decisions.
- C. Mountains made revenue irrelevant.
- D. The Sahyadris automatically created a nation.

Answer: A. Explanation: The exact corrective is enablement without inevitability. The automatic-nation option is geography determinism in its clearest form.

Q66. Which statement avoids proto-national inevitability?

- A. Language alone made all interests identical.
- B. Maratha political identity emerged through multiple service, landed, linguistic and conflict processes.
- C. No political identity existed at all.
- D. A modern nation-state existed unchanged in 1645.

Answer: B. Explanation: The multiple-process formulation avoids both anachronism and denial. The unchanged-nation claim is the target error.

Q67. What corrects the 'exclusively Hindu administration' claim?

- A. No Muslim sailor or officer could serve.
- B. All royal ritual was absent.
- C. Hindu royal idiom coexisted with Deccani institutional borrowing and diverse personnel.
- D. Every office was a Mughal invention.

Answer: C. Explanation: Plurality is the key. The no-Muslim-service option is a factual and interpretive overclaim.

Q68. Which early-fort wording is safest?

- A. Treat Surat as an early hill fort.
- B. Date all forts to the 1700s.
- C. Call Rajgad a simple capture without qualification.
- D. Describe Torna, Murumbdev/Rajgad and Kondana with capture/development distinctions.

Answer: D. Explanation: Action-specific wording prevents a common factual error. Surat is a port, so its inclusion tests basic spatial discipline.

Q69. How should an answer handle Afzal Khan's first blow?

- A. State mutual suspicion and source variation rather than declare certainty.
- B. Treat it as a revenue survey.
- C. Say sources never mention the meeting.
- D. Choose a version because it is more dramatic.

Answer: A. Explanation: The issue is contested sequencing. Drama is not a criterion of historical certainty.

Q70. What corrects 'Purandar was final surrender'?

- A. It made Jai Singh a Maratha king.
- B. It was a negotiated incorporation effort retaining a base and service relationship.
- C. It abolished every fort.
- D. It ended the Agra episode.

Answer: B. Explanation: Retention and later conflict disprove final-surrender language. The Agra option reverses chronology.

Q71. What corrects basket-escape certainty?

- A. Use it as evidence for navy size.
- B. Invent an exact basket count.
- C. Escape is secure, but the basket/sweetmeat mechanism must be labelled a source version.
- D. Deny the escape itself.

Answer: C. Explanation: The method preserves event core while qualifying detail. Exact invented count is a classic false precision trap.

Q72. Why is 'Ashtapradhan cabinet' inaccurate?

- A. It was created by Tarabai after 1700.
- B. The offices had no functions.
- C. It means there were nine ministers.
- D. It imports collective modern cabinet responsibility into ruler-centred offices.

Answer: D. Explanation: The problem is analogy, not the existence of offices. Tarabai chronology is a separate error.

Q73. What corrects 'deshmukhs and jagirs were abolished'?

- A. Shivaji curbed and used intermediaries but did not erase hereditary rights or all assignments.
- B. Revenue was no longer collected.
- C. Every village became directly ruled without mediation.
- D. Mirasdars ceased to exist everywhere.

Answer: A. Explanation: Continuity with constraint is the discriminator. Direct-rule absolutism turns reform into an unproven revolution.

Q74. How should the two-fifths figure be used?

- A. As Sambhaji's mansab.
- B. As a debated, source-specific assessment claim, not universal incidence.
- C. As exact proof for every village.
- D. As a naval levy.

Answer: B. Explanation: The number needs context and qualification. Universalisation is the test's intended error.

Q75. Which correction separates chauth from sardeshmukhi?

- A. Neither involved fiscal claims.
- B. Both are fort ranks.
- C. Chauth is one-quarter; sardeshmukhi is an additional ten-percent claim.
- D. Both mean the same one-quarter amount.

Answer: C. Explanation: The two rates and rationales are distinct. 'Same amount' is the standard close distractor.

Q76. Which correction avoids reducing chauth to sovereignty or plunder only?

- A. It had no collectors.
- B. It always settled lawful title.
- C. It was entirely voluntary charity.
- D. It functioned through protection claims, coercion and overlapping political authority.

Answer: D. Explanation: The answer keeps bargaining and coercion together. The lawful-title claim makes collection mechanically sovereign.

Q77. What corrects the blue-water navy myth?

- A. The evidence supports regional coastal capability, not oceanic empire-scale power.

- B. Every vessel could cross the Atlantic.
- C. Sea forts had no strategic role.
- D. Local sailors did not matter.

Answer: A. Explanation: Scale is the issue, not absence. Atlantic capability is an anachronistic exaggeration.

Q78. What corrects 'Sambhaji's execution ended resistance'?

- A. No forts were used again.
- B. It removed a head while making resistance more decentralised and difficult to negotiate.
- C. Aurangzeb then left the Deccan.
- D. All commanders disappeared.

Answer: B. Explanation: The causal result is diffusion, not extinction. The no-forts option ignores the continuing fort war.

Q79. What corrects 'annexation automatically strengthened the empire'?

- A. It ended logistics.
- B. It guaranteed high realised revenue.
- C. It increased claims and territory while removing buffers and multiplying costs.
- D. It eliminated local enemies.

Answer: C. Explanation: The gain-cost paradox is the intended insight. Guaranteed revenue confuses acquisition with collection.

Q80. What corrects 'jagirdari crisis means only too many nobles or instant collapse'?

- A. It had no link to the Deccan war.
- B. It proves total bankruptcy in one year.
- C. It was a single-cause arithmetic shortage.
- D. It joined jagir quality, jama-hasil gaps, war, resistance, transfers and troop maintenance strain.

Answer: D. Explanation: The crisis is multi-causal and maturational. The one-year-bankruptcy choice turns structural strain into a cartoon.

Semantic-completeness coverage drills - Medieval Topic 23

Drill	Minimum route	Fatal trap
Regional setting	terrain + service + agrarian/coastal institutions	geography caused state
Shahji	mobile Ahmadnagar/Mughal/Bijapur service	nationalist continuity
Forts	store/refuge/pass/revenue/relief network	isolated invincible forts
Purandar/Agra	23/12 + Sambhaji rank -> status breakdown	permanent settlement
Coronation	sovereignty/Kshatriya/Maratha hierarchy	modern nationalism
Administration	eight offices + ruler responsibility + local negotiation	cabinet/abolished intermediaries
Revenue	assessment + chauth 1/4 + sardeshmukhi 10%	merge the claims
Military/navy	mobility/intelligence + littoral force	only raids/blue-water navy
Successors	Sambhaji -> Rajaram/Gingee -> Tarabai	execution ended resistance
Annexation	buffers removed + commitments added	conquest equals pacification
Jagirdari crisis	be-jagiri + jama/hasil + war/chauth/local power	only mansab numbers
Verdict	state-building plus Mughal logistical-fiscal overextension	single-cause decline

PYQ: zero direct verified Topic-23 CSE routes, 2018-2026; Mains has no key.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PART IX - PRACTICE AND ANSWER WRITING

Transparent PYQ audit and route decision

Audit scope: Local official/OCR CSE Prelims and GS-I material for 2018-2026, the repository routing ledgers, and available official answer-key material were searched for exact direct questions on Shivaji, Maratha administration, Ashtapradhan, chauth/sardeshmukhi, forts, Purandar, coronation, navy, Sambhaji, Aurangzeb's Deccan and jagirdari crisis.

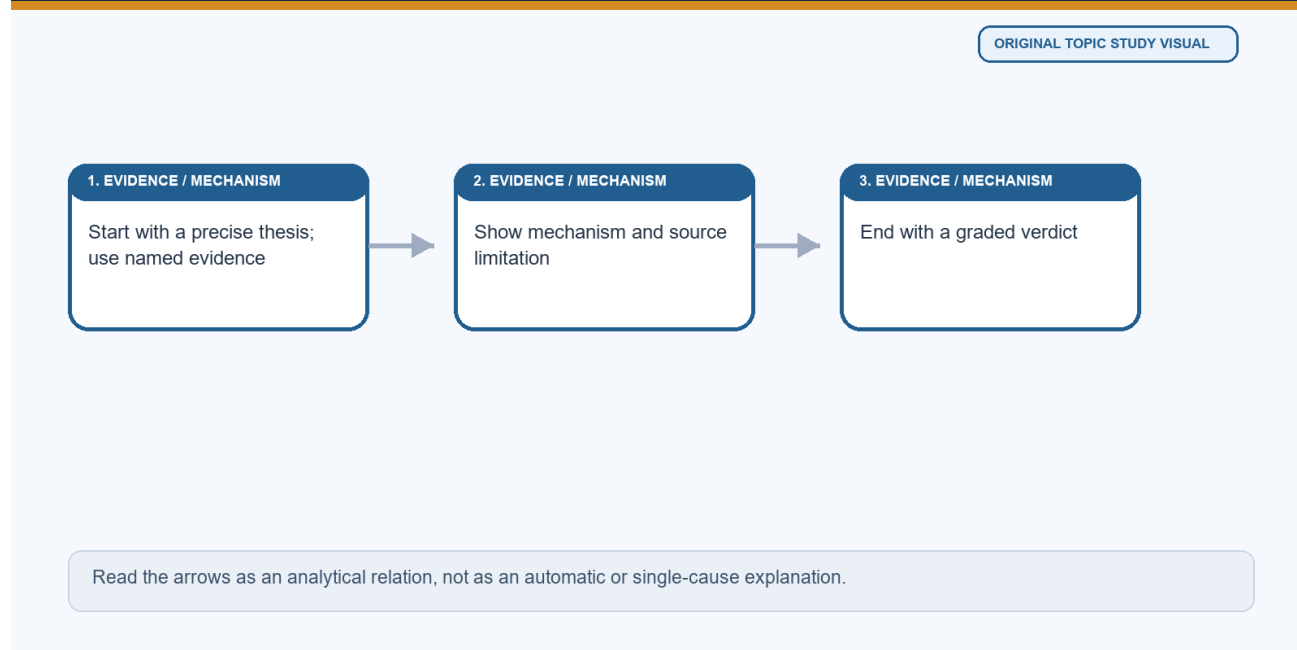
Result: No direct verified CSE 2018-2026 owner PYQ was located for this Topic 23 cluster. The routing ledgers do not assign a direct question to Topic 23; nearby generic Maratha Confederacy/eighteenth-century, UNESCO/current-affairs, Deccan geography and the 2024 Bhatkal-fort question belong elsewhere and are deliberately not misrouted. Local OCR searching also found no exact direct wording in the available official paper corpus.

Workbook policy consequence: There is no fabricated 'official PYQ' or unofficial wording dressed up as one. No official key is claimed. The exercise set below is original practice, clearly marked as such. If a future direct question is added, preserve original option order and label any key as INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED unless an official key is present.

Adjacent evidence, not PYQ substitution: Satish Chandra's interpretation of Purandar/Agra, the Deccan war and the jagirdari mechanism is used for analytical practice. It is not a claim that UPSC has asked a word-for-word question on this topic.

Examiner-grade solved Mains practice (12 answers)

Mains answer spine: claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification



Visual 78: examiner-grade answer spine

Visual 78: examiner-grade answer spine. Original deterministic study visual; schematic maps are NOT TO SCALE where marked.

Mains 1 - 10 marks | 150 words

Question: Explain how the ecology of the western Deccan contributed to, but did not determine, Shivaji's rise.

Directive alignment: Explain a conditional contribution, then reject determinism.

Introduction: The western Deccan supplied an operational setting rather than an automatic political outcome. Sahyadri ridges, Maval valleys, Konkan creeks and passes altered the cost of movement, supply and surveillance.

Claim - evidence - analysis: First, hill forts such as the early Poona-Maval nodes linked defensive height to stores, garrisons and signals. This made short, informed movement possible; it did not make every hill-holder sovereign. Second, Javli in 1656 mattered because control over a rival political position opened routes toward Satara and the Konkan. The evidence shows terrain became useful only when combined with coercion and local recruitment. Third, the Konkan coast connected forts, creeks, customs and maritime rivals, creating a coastal dimension to state capacity.

Qualification: Bijapur's distractions, Shahji's service-world connections, deshmuks and village networks, negotiations and fiscal organisation are indispensable. The same landscape also contained rival chiefs and imperial armies. Geography neither explains a homogeneous 'Maratha people' nor makes diplomacy superfluous.

Verdict: Shivaji converted ecological advantages into a political network through forts, information, local mediation and revenue; ecology enabled the repertoire, while organisation made it durable.

Why this earns marks: It answers the conditional directive, uses named spatial evidence and explicitly blocks geography determinism.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on "Explain how the ecology of the western Deccan contributed to, but did not determine,...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Explain how the ecology of the western Deccan contributed to, but did not determine,...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 2 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Assess the role of forts in Shivaji's state-building.

Directive alignment: Assess means weigh functions, evidence and limitation rather than narrate captures.

Introduction: Shivaji's forts were infrastructure of state formation: military nodes, administrative stores, communication points and visible claims to authority.

Military and operational role: The 1645-47 early phase - Torna, Murumbdev developed as Rajgad, and Kondana - created a Poona-Maval base. The action-specific wording matters: development and renaming are not identical to capture. Javli in 1656 then tied Maval access to Satara-Konkan routes. Fort stores, garrisons and signals made mobile operations sustainable; ganimi kava was not movement without logistical anchorage.

Administrative and fiscal role: Forts protected grain, arms, records and refuge, while officers such as havaldar and sabnis show the need to divide command and record functions. This made a fort an administrative as well as battlefield institution. Raigad's coronation setting in 1674 also turned a fortified centre into a spatial statement of sovereignty.

Strategic limitation: Forts changed hands. Aurangzeb's c.1700-05 siege-recapture cycle demonstrates that capture did not secure a final political outcome. A fort without nearby support, revenue and information could become an expensive liability. The network, rather than any isolated castle, was decisive.

Verdict: Forts formed the skeleton of Shivaji's regional state, but their value arose from integration with local society, supply, revenue and mobile warfare.

Why this earns marks: It uses early forts, Javli, Raigad and later siege cycles as evidence, differentiates functions and gives a qualified verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess the role of forts in Shivaji's state-building.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Assess the role of forts in Shivaji's state-building.”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 3 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Examine Purandar and Agra as a failed attempt to incorporate Shivaji into Mughal strategy.

Directive alignment: Examine both negotiation and failure, avoiding a final-surrender narrative.

Introduction: Purandar and Agra reveal that Mughal-Maratha relations could move between coercion and incorporation; their failure was political and structural, not simply ceremonial.

Purandar as incorporation: Jai Singh's 1665 strategy combined siege, diplomacy and a forward Bijapur policy. The treaty's secure terms - 23 forts ceded, 12 retained, and Sambhaji's mansab of 5000 - show a hierarchy trying to bind Shivaji to service while preserving a territorial base. This is more complex than surrender: service obligations and strategic bargaining remained.

Agra as rupture: At Agra in 1666, court rank and reception communicated political status. Shivaji's perceived insult, confinement and later escape turned an unstable agreement into mistrust. The escape is secure; basket/sweetmeat mechanics are source-version material. Satish Chandra's criticism of Aurangzeb's undervaluation of Shivaji captures the missed alliance value that Jai Singh had seen.

Qualification: A stable settlement was not guaranteed. Shivaji sought autonomy and could deploy negotiation instrumentally; Mughal hierarchy and Maratha sovereignty were difficult to reconcile. Thus the event should not be reduced to one ruler's bad manners.

Verdict: Purandar created a viable but fragile incorporation channel; Agra destroyed the political confidence needed to sustain it.

Why this earns marks: It gives exact terms, explains court status as politics, qualifies the counterfactual and distinguishes secure event from legend.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Examine Purandar and Agra as a failed attempt to incorporate Shivaji into Mughal strategy.”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Examine Purandar and Agra as a failed attempt to incorporate Shivaji into Mughal strategy.”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 4 - 10 marks | 150 words

Question: How did the coronation of 1674 strengthen Shivaji's kingship?

Directive alignment: Explain mechanisms of strengthened kingship, not a ritual list.

Introduction: Raigad's coronation in 1674 transformed accumulated power into an explicit claim of chhatrapati sovereignty in the idiom of contemporary hierarchy.

Mechanisms: Gaga Bhatta's role and Kshatriya genealogy addressed a status problem: royal ritual could place Shivaji above other chiefs and make diplomacy with Deccani sultans more legible. The ceremony connected royal household, fort-centre and revenue-bearing territory to a public language of authority. It also helped consolidate a

Maratha political sentiment without requiring a modern nationalist reading.

Qualification: Genealogical dispute demonstrates that legitimacy was contested, not automatically accepted. The coronation did not erase Deccani institutional borrowing, local intermediaries or the practical need for coercion and revenue. If a second ceremony is mentioned, its ritual rationale and source must be supplied rather than invented.

Verdict: Coronation made sovereignty visible and negotiable in its own period, but it crowned a state-building process rather than replacing it.

Why this earns marks: It treats ritual as political evidence, uses Gaga Bhatta/Raigad precisely and prevents anachronism.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “How did the coronation of 1674 strengthen Shivaji's kingship?”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “How did the coronation of 1674 strengthen Shivaji's kingship?”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 5 - 20 marks | 250 words

Question: Discuss Shivaji's administration and revenue policy without treating it as either a modern bureaucracy or a peasant revolution.

Directive alignment: Discuss requires a balanced institutional account with two explicit rejected extremes.

Introduction: Shivaji developed ruler-centred institutions that enhanced oversight and fiscal capacity while continuing to work through local intermediaries and inherited Deccani practices.

Administration: The Ashtapradhan named Peshwa, Amatya/Mazumdar, Sachiv, Mantri/Waqia-navis, Senapati/Sar-i-naubat, Sumant/Dabir, Nyayadhis and Panditrao. Their existence demonstrates differentiated functions, but they were individually responsible to the ruler, not a collective cabinet. Later Peshwa dominance cannot be retrojected. In forts, divided roles including havaladar and sabnis suggest checks over command, stores and records, although a universal rigid chart should not be asserted.

Revenue and society: Annaji Datto's assessment around 1679 used measurement and classification. It improved calculation, but jama is not *hasil*: local conditions determined realisation. The figure of about two-fifths plus cesses appears in some accounts and must be labelled debated/source-specific. Patils, kulkarnis, *deshmukhs*, *mirasdars* and cultivators remained active. Shivaji curbed illegal exactions and some intermediary autonomy; he did not abolish hereditary rights, all *mokasa/jagir* or local mediation. Cash salaries for regular troops were an instrument of control, not a universal social transformation.

Verdict: The system was a capable regional state apparatus combining oversight, records and fiscal reform with negotiated local power and extraction.

Why this earns marks: It names offices, links assessment to collection, rejects both anachronistic bureaucracy and hagiographic abolition, and includes evidence-led limits.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Discuss Shivaji's administration and revenue policy without treating it as either a modern...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Discuss Shivaji’s administration and revenue policy without treating it as either a modern...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 6 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Evaluate the relationship between Shivaji’s military system and coastal strategy.

Directive alignment: Evaluate interaction and scale; do not list weapons or forts.

Introduction: Shivaji’s military system joined mobile land warfare to a regional coastal strategy, both sustained by forts, intelligence and local labour.

Land system: Mavali infantry, fort garrisons and cavalry categories supplied complementary capabilities. Bargirs were associated with state-provided horse/equipment, whereas silhedars maintained their own; the distinction illuminates organisation rather than a complete social census. Ganimi kava describes surprise, intelligence, supply disruption and avoidance of unfavourable battle, anchored by forts and stores. It should not be translated into modern ideological insurgency.

Coastal system: Konkan creeks, customs and sea forts connected defence and commerce. Engagements with the Sidis of Janjira, Portuguese and English made coastal capacity strategically valuable. Koli, Bhandari, Muslim and other sailors/commanders show why the navy cannot be described as socially or religiously homogeneous. Vessels such as gurabs and galivats should be named only when source context is clear.

Qualification: This was not a blue-water empire-scale navy, and the number of vessels should not be inflated. Nor could fort-mobility neutralise Mughal artillery and siege capacity in every setting.

Verdict: The strength lay in integration: forts, local intelligence, mobile war and coastal defence enlarged the state’s range without making it omnipotent.

Why this earns marks: It gives exact military distinctions, treats coast as political economy and adds the needed scale caution.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on “Evaluate the relationship between Shivaji’s military system and coastal strategy.”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Evaluate the relationship between Shivaji’s military system and coastal strategy.”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 7 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Assess the religious character of Shivaji’s kingship.

Directive alignment: Assess competing evidence rather than affirm either communal slogan.

Introduction: Shivaji’s kingship used a recognisable Hindu royal idiom, but its administrative practices and personnel make an exclusive communal-state description historically inadequate.

Evidence for royal idiom: The 1674 Raigad coronation, Gaga Bhatta’s Kshatriya genealogy and claims of protection deployed Sanskritised status language. These acts mattered because royal legitimacy was contested and needed ritual articulation. They can support an argument about sovereignty and political identity.

Evidence for plurality: The state borrowed from Deccani and Persianate administrative practice and included Muslim officers and sailors alongside varied local groups. Coastal strategy depended on Koli, Bhandari and Muslim expertise; diplomacy was pragmatic. These facts do not negate Hindu idiom; they show that political institutions cannot be deduced from ceremony alone.

Source discipline: Claims about mosques, Qurans, women or universal protection need a named act, date and source genre. A bakhar anecdote, an administrative order and local practice have different reaches. Hindavi Swarajya

needs provenance and cannot automatically mean a modern nation-state.

Verdict: Shivaji's kingship combined Hindu royal legitimacy with Deccani institutional continuity and practical plurality; its historical specificity is lost in both perfect-tolerance and exclusive-Hindu-state myths.

Why this earns marks: It has a clear thesis, named evidence, source method and a balanced but non-evasive conclusion.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess the religious character of Shivaji's kingship.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess the religious character of Shivaji's kingship.", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 8 - 20 marks | 250 words

Question: Could a political settlement have prevented Aurangzeb's Deccan impasse? Analyse cautiously.

Directive alignment: Analyse an alternative without claiming certainty.

Introduction: A settlement was plausible at several moments, but not predetermined; it had to reconcile Mughal hierarchy with a growing Maratha autonomy project.

Evidence for possibility: Jai Singh's Purandar strategy in 1665 recognised Shivaji's military and political usefulness against Bijapur. The treaty's 23/12-fort arrangement, Sambhaji's mansab 5000 and service obligations supplied a framework for incorporation. Agra's rank dispute, confinement and escape in 1666 then damaged confidence. Satish Chandra's judgement that Aurangzeb undervalued Shivaji identifies a strategic error: an opponent who might have become a stakeholder was treated narrowly.

Why settlement remained difficult: Shivaji retained forts and independent objectives; Mughal service language could not easily contain sovereign claims sharpened by the 1674 coronation. Later, Sambhaji's strategic field, annexation of Bijapur and Golconda, and growing mistrust increased stakes. A post-1689 settlement also faced decentralised actors rather than one recognised head.

Qualification: Counterfactuals cannot turn an unrealised agreement into proof. Aurangzeb's choices mattered, but war also grew from imperial sovereignty, local networks, fiscal interests and rival political ambitions.

Verdict: A durable settlement was possible enough to expose the cost of its neglect, but structural incompatibility and changing actors mean it cannot be called certain.

Why this earns marks: It uses Purandar/Agra evidence, states the counterfactual test and gives a reasoned limitation.

Demand decoding: The directive **analyse** requires a direct position on "Could a political settlement have prevented Aurangzeb's Deccan impasse? Analyse cautiously.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Could a political settlement have prevented Aurangzeb's Deccan impasse? Analyse cautiously.", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 9 - 10 marks | 150 words

Question: Explain why Sambhaji's execution did not end the Maratha challenge.

Directive alignment: Explain causal mechanism after a leadership loss.

Introduction: Sambhaji's capture at Sangameshwar and execution in 1689 removed a recognised head, but it did not remove the fort, command and fiscal networks that sustained resistance.

Mechanism: The execution altered negotiation by eliminating a leader with whom an imperial settlement might have been discussed. Rajaram's move toward Jinji supplied strategic depth; commanders such as Santaji Ghorpade and Dhanaji Jadhav could attack communications and dispersed detachments. Ramchandra Pant Amatya and Shankaraji Narayan represent administrative and networked dimensions. Chauth collection through agents increasingly overlapped with Mughal fiscal claims.

Qualification: Do not claim decentralisation was automatic unity or that the Mughal army was powerless. Imperial siege campaigns remained formidable; the difficulty was weak strategic return from repeated capture and recapture.

Verdict: Execution shifted the form of the conflict from a more centralised opponent to a diffuse, locally embedded challenge.

Why this earns marks: It uses named post-1689 actors and shows a causal shift rather than a sentimental assertion.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on "Explain why Sambhaji's execution did not end the Maratha challenge.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Explain why Sambhaji's execution did not end the Maratha challenge.", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 10 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Evaluate Tarabai's contribution to the survival of Maratha resistance.

Directive alignment: Evaluate agency, evidence and limitation.

Introduction: Tarabai's regency after Rajaram's death in 1700 was political leadership in a war of legitimacy, patronage and dispersed command, not merely symbolic succession.

Contribution: She provided a dynastic focus at a moment when Aurangzeb expected central leadership to collapse. Her leadership helped coordinate resistance that used forts, local networks and commanders such as Santaji/Dhanaji traditions. The c.1700-05 siege-recapture pattern shows the context: Mughal forces could take forts, but their investment in time, supply and garrison did not always produce stable control. Tarabai's political work made a decentralised war claim continuity and direction.

Administrative implication: A regency had to manage relationships among commanders, fiscal claims and local patrons. This is why gendered descriptions of a passive widow miss the evidence of rule. It also prevents an answer from reducing survival solely to terrain or male battlefield heroism.

Qualification: Coordination could be uneven, and later Shahu/civil-war developments should not be imported as if they were already settled in 1700. Mughal military capacity persisted; resistance did not equal immediate triumph.

Verdict: Tarabai was central to transforming a leadership crisis into a continuing political resistance, though success rested on a wider network rather than one individual.

Why this earns marks: It makes her agency institutional and strategic, uses siege-cycle context and avoids both iconisation and erasure.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on "Evaluate Tarabai's contribution to the survival of Maratha resistance.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Evaluate Tarabai's contribution to the survival of Maratha resistance.”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 11 - 20 marks | 250 words

Question: Discuss the jagirdari crisis as a combined fiscal, administrative, agrarian and military problem.

Directive alignment: Discuss a mechanism with four linked dimensions, not a single-cause definition.

Introduction: The jagirdari crisis was a failure in the fit between rank/service claims, revenue assignments and what war-disturbed society could actually yield. It matured under the Deccan war; it was neither simple bankruptcy nor a mere surplus of nobles.

Fiscal dimension: Jama was assessed revenue; hasil was actual collection. An apparently adequate jagir could yield poorly because assessment was inflated, areas were disturbed or collection was costly. Be-jagiri meant shortage of assignable productive/usable jagirs, not simply lack of paper labels. Topic 21's month-scale roots show the problem preceded its mature Deccan form.

Administrative and agrarian dimension: Transfers, corruption, factional pressure, new entrants and khanazads competed for assignments. Zamindars, deshmukhs and local armed groups mediated or resisted revenue. Annexed Bijapur/Golconda districts added nominal jama and claimants, but also difficult administration. Collection pressure could be shifted down through intermediaries toward cultivators, though locality varied.

Military dimension: A jagirdar unable to realise income could not maintain required contingents. Maratha agents/kamaishdars collected chauth alongside Mughal claims; private pacts could reduce immediate disruption yet normalise parallel authority. Thus weak hasil led to troop shortfall, harder campaigns and further disturbance.

Verdict: The crisis was a feedback system in which fiscal mismatch, administrative competition, social resistance and war weakened each other without making the empire instantly powerless.

Why this earns marks: It defines terms, supplies a four-part mechanism, connects Topic 21 roots to Deccan pressure and rejects two standard simplifications.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Discuss the jagirdari crisis as a combined fiscal, administrative, agrarian and military...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Discuss the jagirdari crisis as a combined fiscal, administrative, agrarian and military...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 12 - 20 marks | 250 words

Question: Assess the proposition: 'Aurangzeb won Bijapur and Golconda but lost the Deccan.'

Directive alignment: Assess a paradox by distinguishing territorial conquest from governable authority.

Introduction: The proposition captures a real divergence between annexation and political control, but it should not obscure Mughal military capacity or make one ruler the sole cause of imperial strain.

Why 'won' is defensible: Bijapur fell in 1686 and Golconda in 1687. These annexations enlarged imperial territory, removed formal sultanate rivals and brought new revenue claims and nobles. On a conquest map, they were major successes.

Why 'lost' is analytically useful: Buffer removal expanded the Maratha field of action rather than settling it. Long communications, garrisons and Deccan administration raised costs; jama in disturbed territories did not reliably become hasil. Sambhaji's 1689 execution did not end war but preceded diffuse resistance under Rajaram, commanders and later Tarabai. Aurangzeb's personal fort campaigns around 1700-05 encountered repeated siege-recapture cycles. Chauth and private fiscal arrangements further eroded exclusive Mughal authority.

Qualification and source verdict: Religious policy and Rajput rupture from Topic 22, factional competition and earlier mansab-jagir strains were linked factors. Persian chronicles reveal imperial framing; bakhars and local records need corroboration. The empire remained formidable and did not collapse in the Deccan overnight.

Verdict: Aurangzeb achieved annexation but not a durable Deccan settlement. The war intensified a multi-causal administrative and fiscal strain whose post-1707 transition belongs to Topic 25.

Why this earns marks: It gives exact annexation dates, separates map conquest from realisation, includes source method and reaches a graded conclusion.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess the proposition: 'Aurangzeb won Bijapur and Golconda but lost the Deccan.'", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess the proposition: 'Aurangzeb won Bijapur and Golconda but lost the Deccan.'", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.